COMEBACK REHEARSAL



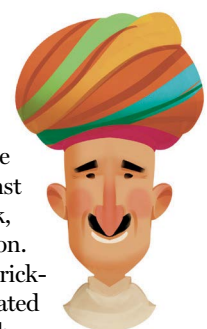
Former MP **Smriti Irani** is back in Amethi, nearly two and a half years after losing the 2024 Lok Sabha election to Congress's Kishori Lal Sharma by over 167,000 votes. The former Union minister and BJP national general secretary had stayed away after the defeat. Her return on October 14, though, was anything but low-key. A grand stage in Gauriganj hosted the induction of three rebel Samajwadi Party MLAs into the BJP, with Irani as chief guest. Such events usually take place in Lucknow or Delhi. Holding one in Amethi, with state biggies in attendance, suggests a larger plan. Is Irani eyeing a comeback, or is the BJP flexing its muscles ahead of the 2027 assembly election in Uttar Pradesh?

SUSPENDED ANIMATION



The compulsory retirement of two Gujarat cadre IAS officers, **K. Rajesh** and **Gaurav Dahiya**, has created a stir in Gandhinagar's bureaucratic corridors. Rajesh, suspended in 2022, faces CBI and ED investigations into alleged corruption involving arms licences and land deals. Dahiya, suspended in 2019 over allegations of bigamy and misconduct, had denied the charges and been reinstated in 2023. Both cases have dragged on for years, raising uncomfortable questions. Why did investigations take so long, only to end in administrative exits rather than judicial verdicts? And will the officers challenge their retirement before a tribunal?

HIT WICKET



Was Rajasthan BJP president **Madan Rathore** echoing the RSS line on keeping communication channels open when he suggested India would back Pakistan against the US? The Congress seized on his remark, launching protests and forcing a clarification. Rathore insisted he meant a hypothetical cricket match, not a military conflict, and reiterated that Pakistan remained an enemy state. Why the usually cautious leader ventured into such controversial territory remains unclear. The BJP has a cautionary precedent. L.K. Advani's praise for Muhammad Ali Jinnah during a 2005 visit there damaged his political standing. Even hypothetical contests can carry real political costs.

Kaushik Deka* with *Amitabh Srivastava, Ashish Misra, Jumana Shah* and *Rohit Parihar

HEALTH WATCH

PATIENT SAFETY
GLARING LAPSES

By **Sonali Acharjee**

A hospital is supposed to be the place where things get better. But what happens when the treatment itself becomes part of the problem? A May 8, 2026, Union health ministry communication, followed by a National Medical Commission directive last week, has drawn attention to an unsettling estimate: medical errors may be associated with as many as 5.2 million patient injuries in India every year. The NMC has called for stronger patient safety measures, putting a long-neglected aspect of healthcare under the lens.



ANI

Medical errors are not always the dramatic surgical blunders that make headlines. They can be as ordinary as a wrong dose of medicine, a missed diagnosis, an infection acquired during a hospital stay, a surgical mistake or a breakdown in communication between doctors and nurses. Often, the problem is less about one careless individual and more about systems that leave too much room for mistakes.

This is what makes the renewed attention to patient safety important. Hospitals have traditionally been judged by their specialists, equipment and ability to perform complicated procedures. Far less attention goes to the quieter safeguards that prevent harm: medication checks, infection-control practices, clear handovers and mechanisms for reporting mistakes without fear.

The larger question is whether hospitals are prioritising patient safety, rather than something to be addressed after things go south. Also, whether medical practitioners will be called to account. Good healthcare is not simply about what a hospital can treat. It is also about what it can prevent.